

PITCHSIDE
My Life in Indian Cricket
by Amrit Mathur
WESTLAND
₹**699; 346** pages

Mathur has also been a cricket writer for four decades, which is what makes this book a delectable read. His knowledge of the game is deep and astute. The sweep of his experiences in the game, as junior player, fan, administrator and journalist, stretches over four decades, from Mansur Ali Khan Pataudi to Virat Kohli and almost every player of consequence in between. Mathur has a keen eye for the unusual. Though part of several major events in modern Indian cricket, he refrains from making himself the subject matter, instead taking on the role of a non-intrusive participant. His journalistic skills come through in information-gathering, highlighting newsworthy episodes, and narrating them in an easy-on-the-ear prose, in a chatty style laced with colloquialisms.

Pitchside is not a linear book on cricket. It's a smorgasbord of experiences, anecdotes and trivia about modern Indian cricket's journey through the eyes of an outsider who frequently found himself on the inside! ■

Ayaz Memon

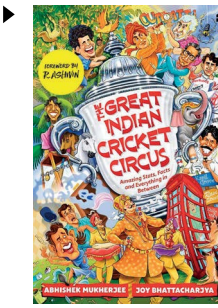
LEISURE

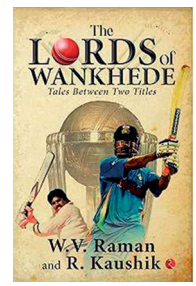
Playing by the Book

THERE'S A SLEW OF NEW BOOKS ON CRICKET

THE GREAT INDIAN CRICKET CIRCUS
Amazing Stats, Facts and Everything in Between
by Abhishek Mukherjee and Joy Bhattacharjya
HARPERCOLLINS INDIA
₹**599** | **456** pages

This is the perfect gift for a cricket fan: 400-plus pages of stats, trivia and the most fascinating anecdotes set in and around the world of Indian cricket. Learn about the former cricketer who was also a fingerprint expert, or the time a snake stopped play, or a kind of mango that came to be named after Tendulkar.



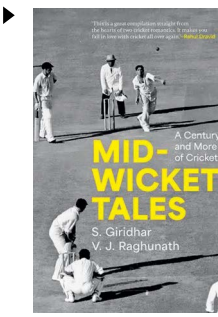


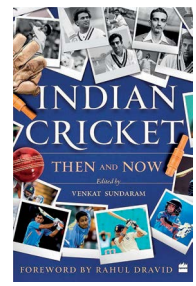
THE LORDS OF WANKHEDE
Tales Between Two Titles
W.V. Raman and R. Kaushik
RUPA PUBLICATIONS
₹**395** | **288** pages

Veteran cricket writer R. Kaushik joins former Team India opening batter W.V. Raman for this book which tracks and chronicles the series of small and large changes that led to India winning the World Cup in 2011—a full 28 years after its first triumph in 1983. The authors also dig a little deeper into how Indian cricket rebounded after the match-fixing scandal to develop a new team culture.

MID-WICKET TALES
A Century and More of Cricket
By S. Giridhar and V.J. Raghunath
SPEAKING TIGER
₹**499** | **380** pages

This cricket book has a bit of everything. There are stats-based essays, anecdotes about quirks and oddities, and beautiful literary explorations of some of the greatest cricketers of all time. First published in 2014, this revised and expanded edition has been released just in time for the World Cup, and contains all-new essays as well.





INDIAN CRICKET Then and Now
Venkat Sundaram (Ed.)
HARPERCOLLINS INDIA
₹**599** | **342** pages

This collection of 50 essays has an ambitious mandate—to cover the entirety of Indian cricket from 1932 when India played its first-ever Test. It does so with a mix of historical essays by renowned cricket writers, wide-ranging interviews with legends as well as whimsical pieces about following the game. Arunabha Sengupta's essay on pre-Independence cricket is a standout, as is Shashi Tharoor's essay on cricket fandom.

by Aditya Mani Jha